



CREATE AN UNBEARABLE SITUATION OF TOTAL INSECURITY WITH NO HOPE OF FURTHER SURVIVAL OR LIFE

THE SIEGE OF SARAJEVO (1992–1996)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Conflicts since the collapse of the USSR

BEFORE

November 9, 1989 The Berlin Wall collapses, leading to the reunification of Germany.

1989 Romania overthrows the ruthless regime of Nicolae Ceaușescu.

1990 In Poland, Hungary, and Czechoslovakia, newly formed center-right parties take power.

1992–1995 The war in Bosnia-Herzegovina results in the death of some 100,000 people.

AFTER

1998–1999 War breaks out in Kosovo between ethnic Albanians and ethnic Serbs. NATO troops intervene.

2014 Fighting erupts between Russians and Ukrainians in eastern Ukraine.

The Siege of Sarajevo, Bosnia, was one of the most appalling tragedies in Yugoslavia's civil war (1991–2002). During the 44-month siege, the city's food and electricity supplies were cut off, and the civilian population was bombarded by nationalist Bosnian Serbs. Thousands of Bosnian Muslims were targeted and murdered.

A new wave of nationalism

Yugoslavia was comprised of six socialist republics: Croatia, Montenegro, Slovenia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Macedonia, and Serbia, each with its own prime minister and constitution. Overall power in Yugoslavia was held by a president, notably communist leader Josip Broz Tito from 1953 to 1980.

After the 1991 breakup of the Soviet Union, a nationalist revival swept Eastern Europe. Croatia and Slovenia's call for independence was opposed by Serbia, and Vukovar, in eastern Croatia, was destroyed by the Yugoslav army under Serbian leader Slobodan Milosevic. When Bosnia also declared independence in 1992, the violence intensified. Bosnian Serbs aimed to create a separate, ethnically pure Serbian state, the Republika Srpska, carving it from the new Republic of Bosnia-Herzegovina. Nationalist Bosnian Serbs, supported by neighboring Serbia, launched a campaign to expel non-Serbs, and during the Siege of Sarajevo, they targeted the majority Bosnian Muslim population.

The Bosnian War ended in 1995, but fighting continued in Kosovo, where ethnic Albanians began a separatist movement against the Serbs. Ethnically based nationalism also led to bloody anti-Armenian pogroms in the Nagorno-Karabakh region and in Baku, the capital of Azerbaijan. In Georgia, violence erupted between the Georgian and Abkhazian population.

The wars in Yugoslavia forced the issue of the global community's responsibility to resolve disputes that threaten wider instability or cause unacceptable human suffering or rights violations. ■